

Advertisement

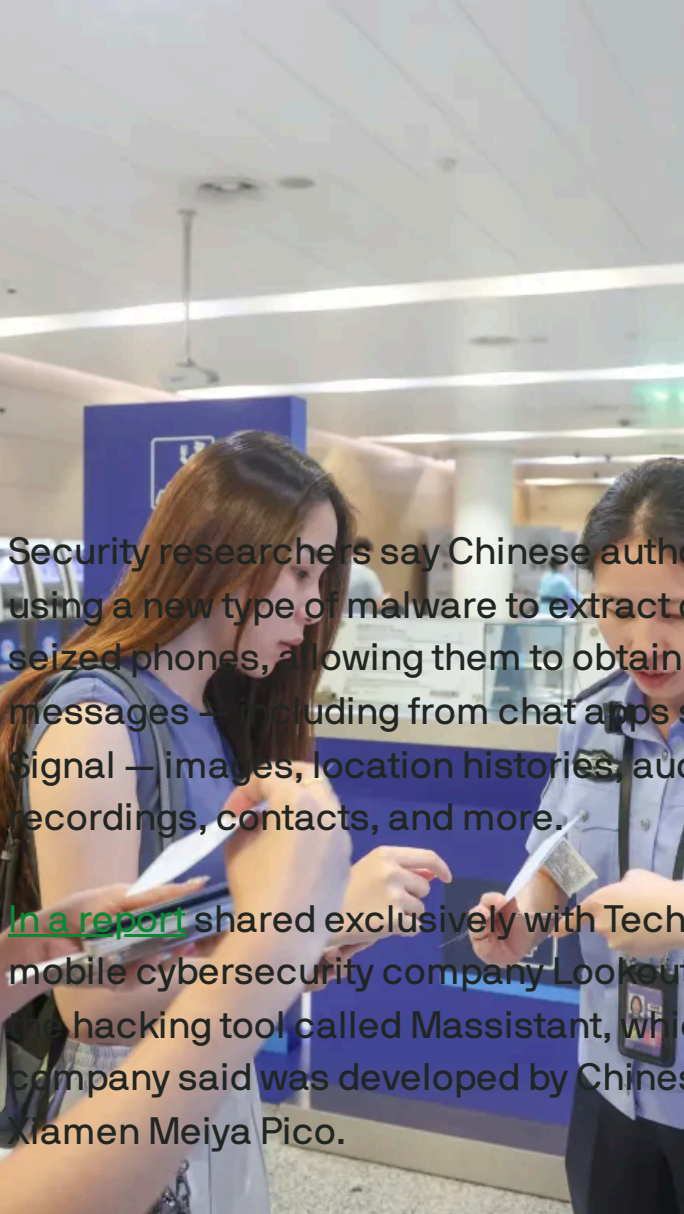
SECURITY



**Chinese authorities are
using a new tool to hack
seized phones and
extract data**

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

— 3:00 AM PDT · July 16, 2025



Security researchers say Chinese authorities are using a new type of malware to extract data from seized phones, allowing them to obtain text messages — including from chat apps such as Signal — images, location histories, audio recordings, contacts, and more.

[In a report](#) shared exclusively with TechCrunch, mobile cybersecurity company Lookout detailed the hacking tool called Massistant, which the company said was developed by Chinese tech giant Xiamen Meiya Pico.

Massistant, [according to Lookout](#), is Android software used for the forensic extraction of data from mobile phones, meaning the authorities using it need to have physical access to those devices. While Lookout doesn't know for sure which Chinese police agencies are using the tool, its use is assumed widespread, which means Chinese residents, as well as travelers to China, should be aware of the tool's existence and the risks it poses.

"It's a big concern. I think anybody who's traveling in the region needs to be aware that the device that they bring into the country could very well be confiscated and anything that's on it could be collected," Kristina Balaam, a researcher at Lookout who analyzed the malware, told TechCrunch ahead of the report's release. "I think it's something everybody should be aware of if they're traveling in the region."

IMAGE CREDITS:
HUANG WEI/XINHUA / GETTY IMAGES

TECH DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

[Book Your Table >](#)

Most Popular



- Key sections of the US Constitution deleted from government's website
- Three weeks after acquiring Windsurf, Cognition offers staff the exit door
- Roku launches Howdy, a \$2.99 ad-free streaming service
- Spotify raises subscription prices
- The uproar over Vogue's AI-generated ad isn't just about fashion

Balaam found several posts on local Chinese forums where people complained about finding the malware installed on their devices after interactions with the police.

“It seems to be pretty broadly used, especially from what I’ve seen in the rumblings on these Chinese forums,” said Balaam.

The malware must be planted on an unlocked device, and works in tandem with a hardware tower connected to a desktop computer, according to a description and pictures of the system [on Xiamen Meiya Pico’s website](#).

Balaam said Lookout couldn’t analyze the desktop component, nor could the researchers find a version of the malware compatible with Apple devices. In an illustration on its website, Xiamen Meiya Pico shows iPhones connected to its forensic hardware device, suggesting the company may have an iOS version of Massistant designed to extract data from Apple devices.

Police do not need sophisticated techniques to use Massistant, such as using [zero-days](#) — flaws in software or hardware that have not yet been disclosed to the vendor — as “people just hand over their phones,” said Balaam, based on what she’s read on those Chinese forums.

Since at least 2024, [China’s state security police](#) have had legal powers to search through phones and computers without needing a warrant or the existence of an active criminal investigation.

“If somebody is moving through a border checkpoint and their device is confiscated, they have to grant access to it,” said Balaam. “I don’t think we see any real exploits from lawful intercept tooling space just because they don’t need to.”

- Lina Khan points to Figma IPO as vindication of M&A scrutiny
- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines



A SCREENSHOT OF THE MASSISTANT MOBILE FORENSIC TOOL'S HARDWARE, TAKEN FROM XIAMEN MEIYA PICO'S OFFICIAL CHINESE WEBSITE

IMAGE CREDITS: XIAMEN MEIYA PICO

The good news, per Balaam, is that MassAssistant leaves evidence of its compromise on the seized device, meaning users can potentially identify and delete the malware, either because the hacking tool appears as an app, or can be found and deleted using more sophisticated tools such as the [Android Debug Bridge](#), a command line tool that lets a user connect to a device through their computer.

The bad news is that at the time of installing MassAssistant, the damage is done, and authorities already have the person's data.

According to Lookout, MassAssistant is the successor of a similar mobile forensic tool, also made by Xiamen Meiya Pico, called [MSSocket](#), which security researchers [analyzed](#) in 2019.

Xiamen Meiya Pico reportedly has a 40% share of the digital forensics market in China, and [was sanctioned by the U.S. government in 2021](#) for its role in supplying its technology to the Chinese government.

The company did not respond to TechCrunch's request for comment.

Balaam said that Massistant is only one of a large number of spyware or malware made by Chinese surveillance tech makers, in what she called “a big ecosystem.” The researcher said that the company tracks at least 15 different malware families in China.

Topics: [Android](#) [China](#) [cybersecurity](#) [Exclusive](#)

[forensics](#) [hacking](#) [Lookout](#) [Security](#)

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [reddit](#) [email](#) [link](#)



Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai
Senior Reporter, Cybersecurity | [X](#) [reddit](#) [in](#)

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai is a Senior Writer at TechCrunch, where he covers hacking, cybersecurity,...

[View Bio](#) >

KEEP READING

SECURITY

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [reddit](#) [email](#) [link](#)

Spyware maker caught distributing malicious Android apps for years

Lorenzo Franceschi-
Bicchierai

— 7:10 AM PST · February 13,
2025

Italian spyware maker SIO, known to sell its products to [government customers](#), is behind a series of malicious Android apps that masquerade as WhatsApp and other popular apps but steal private data from a target's device, TechCrunch has exclusively learned.

Late last year, a security researcher shared three Android apps with TechCrunch, claiming they were likely government spyware used in Italy against unknown victims. TechCrunch asked Google and mobile security firm Lookout to analyze the apps, and both confirmed that the apps were spyware.

IMAGE CREDITS: BRYCE DURBIN / TECHCRUNCH

This discovery shows that the world of [government spyware](#) is broad, both in the sense of the number of companies developing spyware, as well as the different techniques used to target individuals.

In recent weeks, Italy has been [embroiled](#) in an [ongoing scandal](#) involving the alleged use of a sophisticated spying tool made by Israeli spyware maker [Paragon](#). The spyware is capable of remotely targeting [WhatsApp users](#) and stealing data from their phones, and was allegedly used [against a journalist](#) and [two founders](#) of an NGO that helps and rescues immigrants in the Mediterranean.

In the case of the malicious app samples shared with TechCrunch, the spyware maker and its government customer used a more pedestrian

Advertisement

Newsletters

[See More ↗](#)

Subscribe for the industry's biggest tech news

TechCrunch Daily News



Every weekday and Sunday, you can get the best of TechCrunch's coverage.

Startups Weekly



Startups are the core of TechCrunch, so get our best coverage delivered weekly.

TechCrunch Week in Review



Get the best of our coverage, delivered to your inbox every Saturday.

hacking technique: developing and distributing malicious Android apps that pretend to be popular apps like WhatsApp, and customer support tools provided by cellphone providers.

Security researchers at Lookout concluded that the Android spyware shared with TechCrunch is called Spyrtacus, after finding the word within the code of an older malware sample that appears to refer to the malware itself.

Lookout told TechCrunch that Spyrtacus has all the hallmarks of government spyware. (Researchers from another cybersecurity firm, which independently analyzed the spyware for TechCrunch but asked not to be named, reached the same conclusion.) Spyrtacus can steal text messages, as well as chats from Facebook Messenger, Signal, and WhatsApp; exfiltrate contacts information; record phone calls and ambient audio via the device's microphone, and imagery via the device's cameras; among other functions that serve surveillance purposes.

According to Lookout, the Spyrtacus samples provided to TechCrunch, as well as several other samples of the malware that the company had previously analyzed, were all made by SIO, [an Italian company that sells spyware to the Italian government](#).

Given that the apps, as well as the websites used to distribute them, are in Italian, it is plausible that the spyware was used by Italian law enforcement agencies.

A spokesperson for the Italian government, as well as the Ministry of Justice, did not respond to TechCrunch's request for comment.

At this point, it is unclear who was targeted with the spyware, according to Lookout and the other

TechCrunch Mobility



TechCrunch Mobility is your destination for transportation news and insight.

No newsletters selected.

Email address

Subscribe

By submitting your email, you agree to our [Terms](#) and [Privacy Notice](#).



Advertisement

security firm.

Contact Us

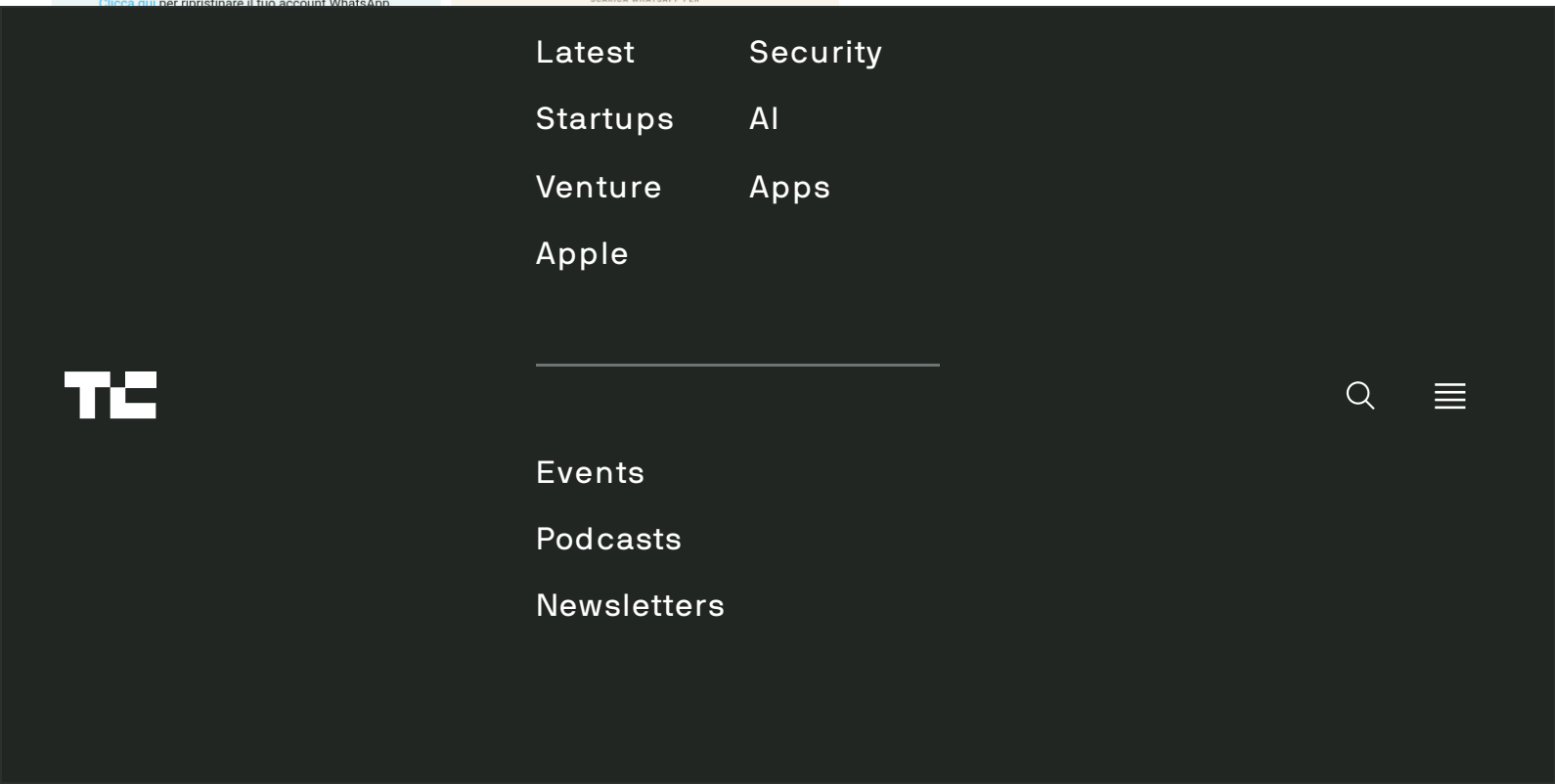
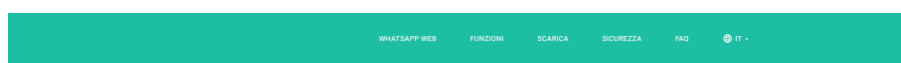
Do you have more information about SIO, or other spyware makers? From a non-work device and network, you can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely on Signal at +1 917 257 1382, or via Telegram and Keybase @lorenzofb, or [email](#). You also can contact TechCrunch via [SecureDrop](#).

SIO did not respond to multiple requests for comment. TechCrunch also reached out to SIO's president and chief executive Elio Cattaneo; and several senior executives, including its CFO Claudio Pezzano and CTO Alberto Fabbri, but TechCrunch did not hear back.

Kristina Balaam, a researcher at Lookout who analyzed the malware, said the company found 13 different samples of the Spyrtacus spyware in the wild, with the oldest malware sample dating back to 2019 and the most recent sample dating back to October 17, 2024. The other samples, Balaam added, were found between 2020 and 2022. Some of the samples impersonated apps made by Italian cellphone providers TIM, Vodafone, and WINDTRE, said Balaam.

Google spokesperson Ed Fernandez said that, "based on our current detection, no apps containing this malware are found on Google Play," adding that Android has enabled protection for this malware since 2022. Google said the apps were used in a "highly targeted campaign." Asked if older versions of the Spyrtacus spyware were ever on Google's app store, Fernandez said this is all the information the company has.

Kaspersky said in [a 2024 report](#) that the people behind Spyrtacus began distributing the spyware through apps in Google Play in 2018, but by 2019 switched to hosting the apps on malicious web pages made to look like some of Italy's top internet providers. Kaspersky said its researchers also found a Windows version of the Spyrtacus malware, and found signs that point to the existence of malware versions for iOS and macOS as well.



Pizza, spaghetti, and spyware

Italy has for two decades been host to some of the world's early government spyware companies. SIO is the latest in a long list of spyware makers whose products have been observed by security researchers as actively targeting people in the real-world.

In 2003, the two Italian hackers David Vincenzetti and Valeriano Bedeschi founded the startup Hacking Team, one of the first companies to recognize that there was an international market for turnkey, easy-to-use, spyware systems for law enforcement and government intelligence

agencies all over the world. Hacking Team went on to sell its spyware to agencies in Italy, Mexico, Saudi Arabia, and South Korea, among others.

In the last decade, security researchers have found several other Italian companies selling spyware, including [Cy4Gate](#), [eSurv](#), [GR Sistemi](#), [Negg](#), [Raxir](#), and [RCS Lab](#).

Some of these companies had spyware products that were distributed in a similar way to the Spyrtacus spyware. Motherboard Italy found [in a 2018 investigation](#) that the Italian justice ministry had a price list and catalog showing how authorities can compel telecom companies to send malicious text messages to surveillance targets with the goal of tricking the person into installing a malicious app under the guise of keeping their phone service active, for example.

In the case of Cy4Gate, [Motherboard found in 2021](#) that the company made fake WhatsApp apps to trick targets into installing its spyware.

There are several elements that point to SIO as the company behind the spyware. Lookout found that some of the [command-and-control servers](#) used for remotely controlling the malware were registered to a company called ASIGINT, a subsidiary of SIO, according to a publicly available [SIO document](#) from 2024, which says ASIGINT develops software and services related to computer wiretapping.

The Lawful Intercept Academy, an independent Italian organization that issues compliance certifications for spyware makers who operate in the country, [lists SIO as the certificate holder](#) for a spyware product called SIOAGENT and lists ASIGINT as the product's owner. In 2022, surveillance and intelligence trade publication Intelligence Online [reported](#) that SIO had acquired ASIGINT.

Michele Fiorentino is the CEO of ASIGINT and is based in the Italian city of Caserta, outside of Naples, according to his LinkedIn profile. Fiorentino says he worked on “Spyrtacus Project” while at another company called DataForense between February 2019 and February 2020, implying that the company was involved in the development of the spyware.

Another command and control server associated with the spyware is registered to DataForense, according to Lookout.

DataForense and Fiorentino did not respond to a request for comment sent by email and LinkedIn.

According to Lookout and the other unnamed cybersecurity firm, there is a string of source code in one of the Spyrtacus samples that points to the developers potentially being from the Naples region. The source code includes the words, “Scetáteve guagliune ‘e malavita,” a phrase in Neapolitan dialect that roughly translates to “wake up boys of the underworld,” which is part of the lyrics of the traditional [Neapolitan song](#) “Guapparia.”

This wouldn’t be the first time that Italian spyware makers left traces of their origins in their spyware. In the case of eSurv, [a now-defunct spyware maker from the southern region of Calabria](#) exposed for having infected the phones of innocent people in 2019, its developers left in the spyware code the words “mundizza,” the Calabrian word for garbage, as well as referencing the name of the Calabrian footballer, Gennaro Gattuso.

While these are minor details, all signs point to SIO as being behind this spyware. But questions remain to be answered about the campaign, including which government customer was behind the use of the Spyrtacus spyware, and against whom.

Topics: [Android](#) [cybersecurity](#) [Exclusive](#) [Google](#)

[hackers](#) [hacking](#) [Italy](#) [Lookout](#) [malware](#)

[Security](#) [SIO](#) [Spyware](#) [WhatsApp](#)

Advertisement

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [t](#) [✉](#) [🔗](#)



Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai
Senior Reporter, Cybersecurity | [X](#) [🦋](#) [@](#)

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai is a Senior Writer at TechCrunch, where he covers hacking, cybersecurity,...

View Bio >

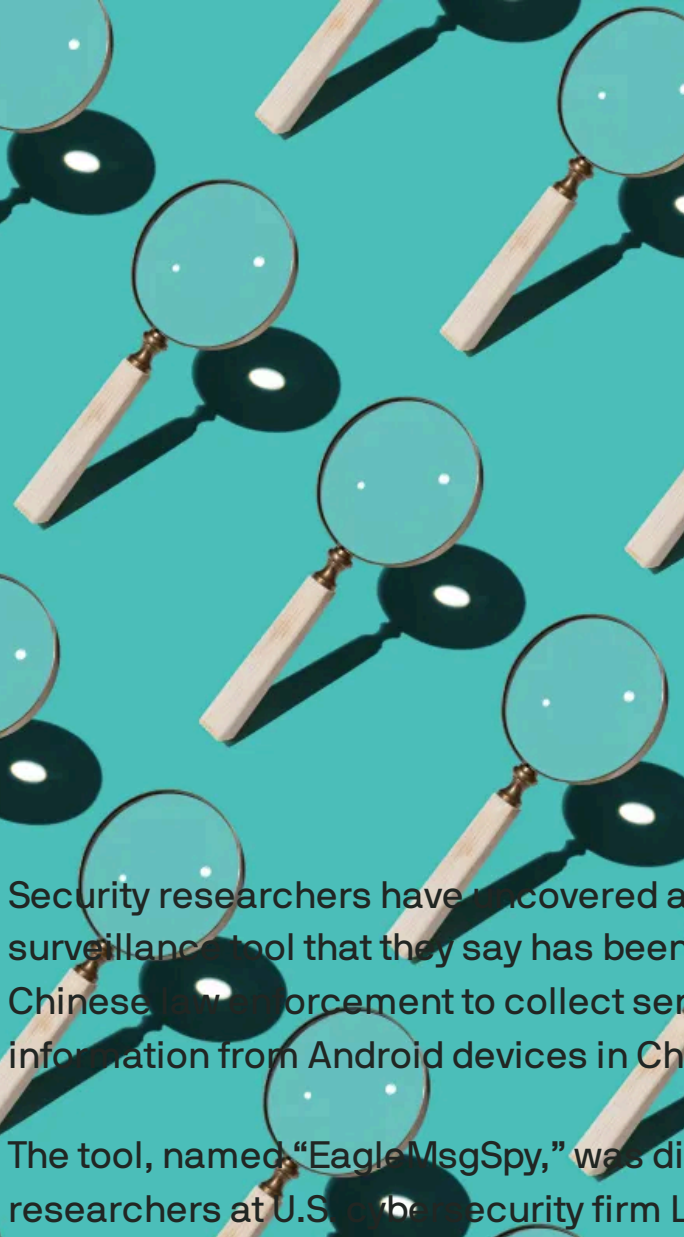
KEEP READING

SECURITY

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [t](#) [✉](#) [🔗](#)

Researchers uncover Chinese spyware used to target Android devices

Carly Page — 6:32 AM PST · December 11, 2024



Security researchers have uncovered a new surveillance tool that they say has been used by Chinese law enforcement to collect sensitive information from Android devices in China.

The tool, named “EagleMsgSpy,” was discovered by researchers at U.S. cybersecurity firm Lookout. The company said at the Black Hat Europe conference on Wednesday that it had acquired several variants of the spyware, which it says has been operational since “at least 2017.”

Kristina Balaam, a senior intelligence researcher at Lookout, told TechCrunch the spyware has been used by “many” public security bureaus in mainland China to collect “extensive” information from mobile devices. This includes call logs, contacts, GPS coordinates, bookmarks, and messages from third-party apps including Telegram and WhatsApp. EagleMsgSpy is also capable of initiating screen recordings on smartphones, and can capture audio recordings of the device while in use, [according to research Lookout shared with TechCrunch](#).

Advertisement

Latest in Security

[See More](#)

SECURITY



A rival Tea app for men is leaking its users' personal data and driver's licenses

Amanda Silberling,
Zack Whittaker
- 14 hours ago

A manual obtained by Lookout describes the app as a “comprehensive mobile phone judicial monitoring product” that can obtain “real-time mobile phone information of suspects through network control without the suspect’s knowledge, monitor all mobile phone activities of criminals and summarize them.”

Balaam said that thanks to infrastructure overlap, she assesses with “high confidence” that EagleMsgSpy has been developed by a private Chinese technology company called Wuhan Chinasoft Token Information Technology. The tool’s infrastructure also reveals the developer’s links to public security bureaus — government offices that essentially act as local police stations — in mainland China, she said.

It’s not yet known how many individuals or who have been targeted by EagleMsgSpy. Balaam said the tool is likely being used predominantly for domestic surveillance, but notes that “anybody traveling to the region could be at risk.”

“I think if it was just about domestic surveillance, they would stand up their infrastructure in some place that we couldn’t access from North America,” Balaam said. “I think it gives us a bit of insight into the fact that they’re hoping to be able to track people if they leave, whether they are Chinese citizens, or not.”

TC

Techcrunch event

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th

SECURITY



Citizen Lab director warns cyber industry about US authoritarian descent

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

- 19 hours ago

TECHCRUNCH DISRUPT 2025



Final call: TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 ticket savings end tonight

TechCrunch Events

- 21 hours ago

Advertisement

anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

Lookout said it also observed two IP addresses tied to EagleMsgSpy that have been used by other China-linked surveillance tools, such as [CarbonSteal](#), which has been used in previous campaigns to target the Tibetan and Uyghur communities.

Lookout notes that EagleMsgSpy currently requires physical access to a target device. However, Balaam told TechCrunch that the tool is still being developed as recently as late 2024, and said “it’s entirely possible” that EagleMsgSpy could be modified to not require physical access.

Lookout noted that internal documents it obtained allude to the existence of an as-yet-undiscovered iOS version of the spyware.

Topics: [Android](#) [China](#) [cybersecurity](#) [malware](#)

[Security](#) [security](#) [Spyware](#) [surveillance](#)

Advertisement



Carly Page

Sr. Reporter, Cybersecurity | X Butterfly M

Carly Page was a Senior Reporter at TechCrunch, where she covered the cybersecurity beat. Prior to that, she had...

View Bio >

Loading the next article



TechCrunch
Staff

Contact Us

Advertise

Crunchboard
Jobs

Site Map

Terms of
Service

Privacy
Policy

RSS Terms of
Use

OpenAI
Perplexity
Cisco
DeepMind
Windsurf
Tech Layoffs
ChatGPT